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consumer affairs, food and public distribution, has insisted that the Centre is working with the state government to complete the procurement by the end of November, farmer unions' patience is wearing thin and they are sporadically blocking state and national highways in protest.

The Crisis Within

The procurement crisis coincides with an internal crisis within AAP's Punjab unit. In late October, Mann expressed his intention to relinquish the post of state convenor of the party, citing the pressures of overseeing 13-14 departments as chief minister. Mann, who has led AAP in Punjab since 2019, got his loyalist Budh Ram appointed as its working president after becoming chief minister in 2022. This gave him unrestricted control over the party's affairs in the state. But, now, he talks of "a dedicated president" to handle party responsibilities full-time.

HAVING RELINQUISHED HIS CHIEF MINISTERIAL DUTIES IN DELHI TO FOCUS ON THE PARTY ORGANISATION, KEJRIWAL'S ATTENTION HAS INCREASINGLY TURNED TO PUNJAB

This comes amid growing scrutiny from the central command in Delhi, particularly following AAP's disappointing performance in the May-June Lok Sabha election, where they secured only three of Punjab's 13 seats—Hoshiarpur, Sangrur and Anandpur Sahib—with a 26 per cent vote share. It marked a sharp decline from their 2022 assembly triumph when, riding piggyback on farmer anger, AAP cornered 92 of the 117 seats, with an impressive vote share of 42 per cent. Beyond mere statistics, the results revealed significant governance gaps and growing voter disenchantment. And clearly, the party's ploy to weave the campaign around the CM—juxta-

CLIPPED WINGS

How the AAP's central leadership has been overruling Bhagwant Mann

- **Bypassing the CM:** Seated in Delhi, AAP high command holds private meetings with Punjab cabinet ministers/MLAs, overlooking Mann
- **Selecting candidates:** Party's official handle releases names of bypoll candidates; Mann takes two hours to congratulate them
- **Strategic replacements:** Chief secretary Anurag Verma ousted for high command's choice, K.A.P. Sinha
- **Finance oversight:** IMF veteran Arbind Modi and economist Sebastian James appointed to oversee Mann regime's fiscal management
- **Cabinet purge:** Two Mann loyalists among four ministers removed; replaced by five fresh faces
- **Inner circle dismantled:** Mann's three key aides—Onkar Singh, Baltej Pannu and Navneet Wadhwa—shown the door. His choice for Wadhwa's replacement swiftly overturned too
- **Family influence curtailed:** Security detail of wife Gurpreet reduced, governance interference checked